

Rukmini Devi Arundale

(1904 -1986)

She helped institutionalise Bharatanatyam. Even as the Anti-Nautch Movement was leading up to the abolition of the Devadasi system in 1947, Rukmini Devi was almost single-handedly giving the old Sadir dance a new, sanctified status in society—with a new name and ethos. Thanks to her connections at home and abroad—"married" too as she was to the Theosophical Society, which was full of foreigners doing social reform in India in the 1930s—she went on to merge the discipline of the West with the knowledge systems of the East, South India to be specific. She was uniquely positioned in history as India was headed towards a fight for freedom, and she became a cause celebre in dance, rescuing it from forced extinction by elaborating the temple style, de-eroticising it to stave off colonial-era stigmas. She was helped by the Theosophical Society to create a space for dance—Kalakshetra—but later, the very same society delinked itself from dance, calling it an 'antithesis' to their stated goals. Arundale showed her acumen by buying beach plots on the outskirts of Madras and combining these to build an entirely new institution. Today, Kalakshetra, as a school of Bharatanatyam and Carnatic, is the "Bolshoi of India". In 1977, Arundale was the preferred choice to be President, but she declined.

Yamini Krishnamurthy

(1940–)

Even when not giving electrifying performances, Yamini Krishnamurthy lit up the stage with her thousand-watt presence. Trained in three principal styles, Bharatanatyam, Kuchipudi and Odissi, she did her alma mater, Kalakshetra, proud by excelling in all. In fact, her decision to learn Odissi from Adiguru Pankaj Charan Das goaded others like Ritha Devi to follow suit. A beacon of the classical arts, no state function in Delhi was complete without her dance presentation. Heads of state waited to get photographed with her. Yamini was India's first prima donna, prima ballerina, prima everything; diva and superstar, all rolled into one. Her elaborate eye make-up is still a trend, as are her mannerisms and pout, very handy in this age of selfies.



Indrani Rahman

(1930-1999)

If Indian dance had one global icon, performing before everyone from Kennedy to Khrushchev and teaching at the Julliard, it was Indrani. Her steps straddled East and West with all the grace of Odissi. And she gave that dance-form a national profile at a time when it was not recognised officially, and would-be icons like Mayadhar Raut and Sanjukta Panigrahi were learning Bharatanatyam at Kalakshetra. Born to American pioneer Ragini Devi and freedom fighter Ramalal Bajpai, Indrani was crowned Miss India in 1952 and was also the first Indian woman to participate in the Miss Universe pageant, all of which won classical dance much attention. Her marriage to famous architect Habib Rahman was the talk of the town.



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